Who were the merchants who took the lead? Or, in other words, who were the promoters of the Swadeshi firm? In the initial days, we find repeated references to a Sena Vana company in newspapers and other contemporary documents. Sena Vana is the Tamil rendering of the initials of S.V. Nallaperumal Pillai. Naming (formally) or referring (informally) to firms after the Tamil initials of their proprietors was common practice.

Hailing from an affluent landholding and trading family, S.V. Nallaperumal Pillai (Figure 2) followed in the footsteps of his father Chinnakannu Pillai and entered the trading business between Tuticorin and Colombo. He also had a flourishing business with interests in salt pans and the export of salt. Additionally, he invested heavily in land and owned houses and landed properties in various parts of Tamilnadu. Given his considerable landholding, he was commonly referred to as Sivapuram *Mittadar* (‘the landlord of Sivapuram’). Given his economic clout, he later became the chairman of Tuticorin municipality, a member of the temple administration board and a director of the Bank of Tamilnadu. A philanthropist of some standing, he was chairman of the Tuticorin Saiva Siddhanta Sabhai—a religious association in which VOC took active part—for some forty years. He also established a school named after himself.[21] All this flowed from his flourishing business interests.